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Populist Attacks on IOs

POPULISM IS a global ideology with broad appeal that has surged dramatically in recent years, creating significant challenges for IOs. As discussed in previous chapters, IOs make convenient targets for populists as elite bureaucracies that constrain domestic sovereignty. Populists thrive by "denouncing the existence of an alliance between domestic and foreign elites seeking to subvert the will of the people" (Rovira Kaltwasser and Taggart 2016, 356). This sentiment is echoed by a former IMF bureaucrat who remarked, "The institution has always been vulnerable to populist, isolationist, and anti-IO leaders."[1]

In this chapter, we delve into the contemporary rise of populism and its implications for IOs. We begin by charting the spread of populism and situating populist opposition to IOs within the context of an evolving multilateral system. Populists, with their disdain for transnational governance and elite-led institutions, have actively worked to undermine IOs in numerous ways. Leveraging novel data on state–IO interactions, we document how populist leaders employ a range of tactics to weaken these institutions.

Our analysis reveals a pattern: Compared with other leaders, populists are far more likely to reduce their participation in IMF programs, withhold or distort critical information from organizations like the World Bank and UNFCCC, and deploy aggressive rhetoric aimed at discrediting the global trade system. These actions highlight the systematic approach populists take to erode the legitimacy and functionality of IOs.